

# Use Open Source Software to Improve Your Productivity



Personal productivity or time management is important for professional growth. Here are a few open source tools that can help you achieve optimum productivity.

Most of us have heard the term 'Productivity Improvement' in the context of the manufacturing sector. But this term has gained importance even in the services sector where you find professionals peering at computers throughout their working hours. One could think of improving the productivity of these professionals, also known as information workers, by increasing their typing speed. But there are better ways available! In this article, I will share my experience with five open source tools that I have used to improve my personal productivity.

The first tool that I want to talk about is *PDFCreator*. Let me confess that I use MS-Office as it is the standard in our organisation. But I need to convert MS-Office documents into PDF files quite often. MS-Office programs do provide a feature to convert MS-Office documents into PDF files. But you can't create PDF files that are password protected or the ones from which text cannot be copied. Thankfully, there exists *PDFCreator*, which provides these features without any cost or hassles. *PDFCreator* installs as a printer; so when you are ready to convert your MS-Office document or even HTML document into a PDF document, just select that printer and print to it. The dialogue box that comes up will have an *Options* button that can be clicked to set permissions for the soon-to-be-generated PDF file, as shown in Figure 1. You can download this software and access help at <http://www.pdfforge.org/>

Another tool that I use quite often is *WikidPad*, which I used to prepare the draft of this article. This is basically a personal wiki wherein the contents are stored on your machine. You can

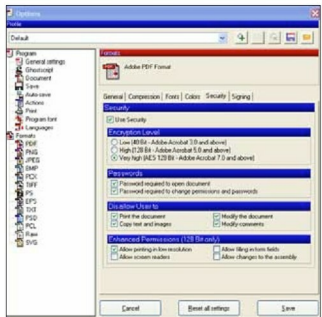


Figure 1: PDFCreator options window

consider it as a notepad with some advanced features. Using Wiki syntax, you can create a hierarchy of documents. You can also paste images within the text and can do a spell check. It's very useful if you regularly write blogs or articles, as you can write and rewrite your draft offline quite conveniently using this tool. Figure 2 shows a screenshot of this tool. More details, along with the installer, are available at <http://wikidpad.sourceforge.net/>